

1914–1923

TOWARDS THE NEW WOMAN

The new woman of the 1920s with her bobbed hair and knee-length dress emerged gradually. The evolution to the modern female silhouette took around ten years and started just before World War I. Maybe the most fundamental change was the gradual revelation of the lower part of women's legs, which put a new emphasis on shoes and, more importantly, on stockings. Flesh and soft pastel colours replaced the dark stockings of the previous age and were made of real or very shiny artificial silk. Equally noticeable was a change in the fashionable ideal: the statuesque, shapely, mature woman was replaced by her bosomless, hipless, thighless, much younger sister. Waistlines rose and dropped, finally settling around the hips. The new silhouette and less rigid clothing necessitated different kinds and fewer items of underwear.



1921



1922



French pattern Almost no traces of the hourglass figure ideal remain. The simple cut of this dress would have made it easier for dressmakers to replicate than previous more elaborate confections. The use of only two muted colours creates visual interest.

Lower waist This simple, striped dress has a Peter Pan collar and matching cuffs. A few darts in the side seam, just above the low waist, allow for a small bust. The black and white of the hat are echoed in the two-tone, lace-up shoes.

La mode simple This French pattern for a summer dress was practical and easy to make. Side skirt panels of patterned fabric make the simple shape more interesting. The same fabric is used to edge the neck and sleeves.

